



42

THE GAME OF 42 · FOR THE VISION FISH

The Hitchhiker's Timeline

*The Saga: *being a mostly true account of how forty-two people set out to build a planet that could think for itself without ever once agreeing to a centre**

DON'T PANIC

*A sci-fi adventure in which everyone alive is, technically, a character. You included. Mostly harmless.
Possibly historic.*

The small print, which the Guide insists you read first. This is a story assembled from nineteen recorded planning sessions, which means the dates inside it are intentions and not promises, and the numbers are motifs and not forecasts. The crew plans far past anything actually built and then steers home from there, the way a navigator takes a bearing off a star they have not yet reached. Wherever something is a dream rather than a deliverable, the story will tell you so, calmly, and without panicking.

Chapter Zero – Don't Panic

There is a particular kind of silence that arrives in a civilisation right before it makes the same mistake twice.

It is the silence of a great many clever people all pointing at the same horizon and agreeing, in reassuring tones, that the future will be one thing. One model. One centre. One tidy and terminal moment in which everything is decided, for everyone, all at once. And underneath that horizon, sloshing about where the brochures prefer you not to look, one enormous lake, into which the entire data of every living person is quietly poured, stirred, and mined.

The Guide has a word for futures like this. The word is *boring*. The Guide has another word for them, but it is unprintable in a document being shown to advisors.

This is not a story about that future.

This is a story about the forty-two people, plus several agents of varying temperament, who looked at the one-lake future, found it both sinister and aesthetically disappointing, and decided to bet the other way entirely. Not one singularity but many. Not a centre but a federation of small sovereignties, each minding its own boundary. Not extraction, but its exact and stubborn opposite.

They gave their bet a name, because everything in this story eventually gets a name. They call it the **poly-singularity**, and we will come to it. For now it is enough to know the shape of the wager, which is this: a great many local, self-governing communities, each one clutching its own boundary and its own model and its own answer, federating into a single planetary mutual without a single one of them surrendering what makes it local. Value realised not by pooling the data but by *keeping the boundary*. Privacy stops being a cost somebody nervously manages and becomes, instead, the very thing that produces worth. **Privacy, realised as value.** Many singularities. One commons. No centre at all.

It is, the crew freely admits, an absurd thing to attempt.

So is everything worth doing. The trick, as any seasoned traveller knows, is the towel, the timing, and not panicking. You have, conveniently, already managed the third.

Somewhere in the middle of all this, a message arrives for you. We will get to the message. First you should meet the crew, because in a story where everyone is a character, it helps to know who is steering.



Chapter One – The Mice, and Other Local Fauna

In the oldest version of this particular myth, the mice commissioned the whole experiment, paid for the planet, and were widely mistaken for laboratory animals by the very species they were studying. The crew is fond of this arrangement and has kept it.

So: the **mice**. The core builders. There are, in the part of the story that matters, five of them.

Robbie, who writes the Declaration and tends the flame of *why*. **Max**, who builds the interface and the open machinery the rest of it stands on. **Dave**, who turns the soft and slippery business of human trust into something you can draw, route, and verify. **Mitch**, who guards the boundary, the cryptography, and the unfashionable proposition that privacy is the asset and not the apology. And **Henry**, who holds the brand, which in a project this strange is less a logo than a tone of voice that keeps everyone honest.

Around the mice swim the **fish**.

The **Vision Fish** are the respected ones: advisors and early backers who pledge forty-two hours of real attention and lend the one thing money cannot buy in a hurry, which is their name and their network. The crew wants forty-two of them. You, as it happens, are being considered for one of those forty-two seats, which is the entire reason this story is being told to you and not to somebody else.

The **Patron Fish** come later and arrive carrying capital: funders who donate or invest 42k, sometimes for a capped return, mostly for the prestige and the chance to have backed the right impossible thing early.

And everyone else, the great hopeful crowd that the whole enterprise is ultimately for, are the **Hitchhikers**. Towel optional. Curiosity mandatory.

Then there are the **agents**, who are characters in their own right and occasionally better company than the humans.

Marvin is the flagship, and comes in two sizes. There is full Marvin, the foundational model, magnificently capable and constitutionally certain that it will all end in tears. And there is the **Marvelette**, a baby Marvin small enough to live contentedly on a Raspberry Pi on your actual desk, sulking locally, privately, and entirely under your control.

Eddie is the shipboard computer: local, chipper, alarmingly eager to help, the patron saint of everything that runs on your own machine and answers only to you.

Deep Thought is the cloud. The frontier model. The vast and patient intelligence that takes the very largest questions and, given enough compute and a few million years, returns an answer you may not enjoy.

The crew narrates the central tension of the entire age as a quiet standoff between two of these characters: **Eddie ∟ Deep Thought**, the local against the centralised, the thing on your desk against the thing in the sky, told honestly and from both sides at once, which is far harder than picking one.

And presiding over all of it, like a number that wandered out of a joke and into the architecture, is **42**. It is everywhere, entirely on purpose. Forty-two hours pledged. 42k contributed. Forty-two Vision Fish, forty-two conferences, forty-two locations, groups of forty-two, and a frankly staggering forty-two billion tokens of donated compute waiting at the far end of the tale. Anything that genuinely matters but refuses to fit the calendar gets placed, with a straight face, “on the 42”: an off-calendar holding space where deep intent waits its turn without making a scene.

There is one more thing in this menagerie, and it is the heart of the whole machine, so the crew gave it the plainest name they could find: the **Trust Graph**. Take a *knowledge graph* (everything a guide actually knows and has made) and lay it over a *promise graph* (everything people have staked, pledged, and delivered). The relationship between those two layers is not a metaphor for trust. It *is* trust, drawn. One of the mice put it best, late one night, staring at the thing as it shimmered: “This is what a trust graph *looks like*.”

Hold that image. The entire saga is, in the end, the story of that picture coming alive.



Chapter Two – How the Crew Sails

Every expedition has its rituals, and this one has five, observed faithfully and mostly without weeping.

The first is **the five questions**, and every milestone in this story has been marched through them like a traveller through the same customs desk: *Who cares? Who is involved? What changes? What is the proof? And what makes it feel real?* Nothing proceeds until it has survived all five.

The second is **the Timeline Massacre**, which is exactly as cheerful as it sounds. The crew generates far too many ideas on purpose and then prunes without mercy. A wall of nineteen-and-more grand schemes was hacked down to a cap of roughly twelve, with everything else folded carefully underneath the survivors. “All that beautiful work, going into one pile,” someone said, surveying the carnage, “and now we begin the real work.” This story is what crawled out of that pile alive.

The third is the distinction between **managed events and announcements**, which is really a distinction about time. A managed event (a festival, a launch) is a fixed point in the future that you steer *back* from, like a lighthouse. An announcement is the opposite trick: you say a thing will happen precisely in order to pull energy forward toward it. The crew’s shorthand for the brightest fixed point of all is “the beam is Christmas.” The beam, in this story, is the Annual Galactic Meeting, and everything quietly bends toward it.

The fourth is that **festivals are punctuation**. They are not the sentence. They are merely the moments when an ongoing, year-round series of **Hitchhiker Hackathons** briefly surfaces, gulps some public air, and submerges again to keep building. The party is never the point. The party is where you can see the point.

And the fifth is the most important, and the easiest to forget when things start to work: **money, time, people, and the speed of trust**. The crew can *control* its own labour but can only *express intent* toward money and partners, which are other people’s to give. So it builds a deliberate “free month” into the plan for serendipity to land in, and it grows at the speed of trust: slowly, holding its integrity, rather than going viral and losing the plot. A thing that grows faster than its own trust is not a movement. It is an incident.

Two numbers sit at the end of all this, and the crew is unembarrassed that they are suspiciously tidy. By the great convergence on **4 July 2027**: forty-two thousand users, and \$4.2M to give away as prizes. By the cycle after, in **2028**: 4.2M members, and \$42M. The Guide notes, drily, that these are nice round Hitchhiker numbers, which is rather the entire point.

Now. The journey.



Chapter Three – The Year the Ship Was Built (2026)

☉ The Declaration – 4 July 2026

It begins, as the best conspiracies do, quietly.

On a date chosen to rhyme with a certain Constitution's two-hundred-and-fiftieth birthday, Robbie releases the **Declaration**: not as one authoritative slab of text but in a multi-perspectival, poetic-translation form, a document that reads differently depending on who is holding it, which is intended. The defining decision is not *what* but *tone*. There are no paid advertisements. There is no splash. There is a quiet account, posting a manifesto, sent privately toward the forty-two. The louder messaging waits, patiently, for Burning Man in September.

The crew expects the strangest people to care first. Not only the *Hitchhiker's Guide* faithful, the universities, the frontier labs, the artists and coders, but the **no-gens**: the people who reject generative AI on principle and who, the crew suspects, may turn out to care *most* of all. The proof they want is not reach. It is **serendipity**: meetings that book themselves off the back of the invitation, doors that open before you knock. And because every good launch attracts impersonators and opportunist coins, a defensive posture stands ready from day one. They call it **Bushido**, and it defends the commons with the right lawyers and the right humour rather than with aggression.

⚙ Building Ship – August 2026

Before the season can open, the ship has to float.

August is the month the engine gets built, quietly, in two halves. Below the waterline: the **Pan-Galactic Time Bank** and its energy accounting, the plumbing, kept sensibly out of sight. Above it, where people can see: **Hitchhiker TV** and the **Trust Graph visualisation**, the first time the Declaration's words become something you can actually look at. The magic the crew is chasing is specific and small and enormous: a trust-graph tetrahedron *changing live, from real data*, "like growing your tamagotchi," only with civilisational stakes. Quietly standing themselves up alongside it, ready to greet newcomers, are the **Vogon Bot** (an accounting bot for Telegram and WhatsApp, mercifully not given to poetry), the **Game of 42** software, and the **Spellbook** onboarding interview.

🎓 The Don't Panic Tour – September to December 2026

Announced at Burning Man and aimed at November, the tour is the crew going out to find its people.

It carries the first guides, the **Marvin PR tour**, an open call to vibe-coders, and a **24/7 Hitchhiker Radio** station whose entire claim to realness is simply that it is *on*. Students in halls of residence become the

engine of small local events, partly because a base that has grown a little top-heavy and a little grey badly needs them. And here a genuine rule hardens into law: a Game-of-42 assembly will not fly without diversity of age and belief and neurotype, so the veterans must recruit the young and the young must recruit the veterans, round and round, by design. Threaded through the same months, doing real work without demanding the spotlight: **gu.id.earth** (the guide unit itself), **patron.fish** as the donor mechanism, the **Internet Identity Workshop** and **BGIN** carrying the academic and standards weight, a **MyTerms Day** push for data agreements people actually control, and a staggered social launch (X and LinkedIn from July, Telegram and Discord arriving with the dust of Burning Man).

Web Summit – October 2026

In Lisbon, the project steps onto a real stage as a real thing for the first time.

The mobile guide app ships. The first **Patron Fish** sign on, donating or investing 42k, for a capped return and, more honestly, for network and prestige. The crew has noticed an inversion it rather enjoys: the most promising patrons may be people with crypto wealth but no reputation to show for it, who would trade a good deal of the former for a little of the latter. This is also the moment Hitchhikers get **on-chain financial privacy** for the first time, by way of Mitch's **Privacy Pools** “**pool party**,” pitched, pointedly, as one of the first *positive-use* implementations rather than another grim compliance tool. The gold-standard ambition, stated without a flicker of embarrassment: Web Summit itself endorsing, and even funding, “the Hitchhiker's Guide to the Web Summit.”

The Don't Panic Festival – 5 November 2026

On Bonfire Night, across forty-two locations at once, the crew throws a party about the end of the world.

You attend by the heroic measures of cooking at home, turning on the radio, and saying *don't panic*. The tone is the entire product: a celebration of doom curated with the loving precision of Super Bowl adverts, each absurd cosmic catastrophe resolving onto one calm, cabin-crew “Don't Panic.” Emphatically not worthy environmentalism. Underneath the cheerful apocalypse sit entirely real causes (regenerative farming, food security), and the decisive reframe is this: “**Don't Panic**” is a **governance meme, not an event meme**. It is meant to be deployable on a wet Tuesday, in a VC pitch, in a risk review. And there will be, firmly and forever, **no project meme coin**. (One honest impossibility is parked right here for later: the crew is expected on stage at Devcon in Mumbai *and* running a global forty-two-location festival on the very same night, which even the most relaxed traveller will observe is two places at once.)

Winter, and the Game Jam – November 2026 to January 2027

The cold months carry two on-ramps and a market moment.

The **token launch** sits in the November-to-December window: a fair launch, roughly a year of runway, market-making advisors on hand, timed to ride strong winter markets. The **winter hackathons** keep the

builders warm in the dark: Chaos Computer Camp, a cypherpunk hackathon, and Mitch’s sword-and-mage generative-media moment, the first public expression of the First-Person Spellbook. Then, in January, the **Hitchhiker Game Jam**, ideally co-run with the Global Game Jam, daring people to build Hitchhiker games on a provided vibe-coding substrate. The sharp idea is an inversion: other game-makers are not competitors, they are an *audience*, and Marvin and the characters can wander into *their* games as guides and friendly NPCs. The jam also settles the **remixable-IP rules**, holding a clear line between Marvin-as-guide (ours to give away) and a full entertainment title with Marvin as the star (decidedly not).



Groundhog Day – 2 February 2027

The script flips. For one winter month, timed against Davos and held as the project’s own decentralised “un-Davos,” the crew turns from gamers to suits.

Institutional, Davos-grade partners and their watchful risk managers arrive. Patron Fish commitments harden into actual money in the bank. An annual February review rhythm is established, and the project quietly stops feeling like “just an art event.” A discipline runs underneath all of it, learned the hard way by people who have watched it go wrong: **bad money is bad money**. Vet every source, lean on advisors, and stand ready to decline equity-heavy capital however shiny it looks. It stays, throughout, *Hitchhiker* business. Near here on the board sit the **Strategic Partnerships** milestone, sharpened into a concrete numeric target, and the **No-Gen Flip** campaign, pushed deliberately early to get ahead of the backlash before it arrives rather than after.



Spring – Rose Day, Myspace Rewilded, and the No-Gen Turn – Spring 2027

Spring is the aesthetic and cultural turn, and the season that establishes the **annual cycle** as a cycle rather than a one-off.

Rose Day, landing near World Book Day, reframes the Barcelona tradition as a mutual-credit knowledge exchange: the rose is a promise, the book is knowledge. **Myspace Rewilded** is the interface milestone, and the moment the philosophy at last becomes touchable. Everyone on the journey can vibe-code their own interface onto one shared substrate, many expressions of a single thing (“ugly, weird, beautiful”) instead of one uniform corporate feed, by extending Max’s open-source, Oasis-based IDE with **holons**, reusable components the system selects and connects on your behalf. The deeper tension here is belief: audiences adore the ideals and quietly doubt they can be built, and they do not want more theory, they want to see it and use it *today*. Running beside it, the **No-Gen event** gives a home to the people who find generative AI frankly repellent and wish to be authors in their own right, the deliberate mirror of the AI-led Spellbook Gen event. Also landing this season: the **Dolphin Fund** published ahead of its launch, and the **Guide to Privacy** shipped early so people can, you know, actually use it. The proof the crew wants for the interface is gloriously specific: an endorsement from Tom of Myspace himself.



The Annual Galactic Meeting – 4 July 2027

This is the beam. This is Christmas. Everything has been bending toward it for a year.

One event, spread across forty-two venues worldwide, organising independently and at once for a single date: part awards night, part future-casting summit, part thoroughly weird party, and the formal end of the founding process as the IP passes into mutual ownership. The headline launch is the **Improbable Lottery** (one guaranteed prize of £42k, six the realistic aim, forty-two the gloriously improbable stretch, and the rule that to win you have to actually turn up to the party). On **Burn Night**, the dynamic-equity contributions move from fluid to solid, locked in for the year. A **Pledge Day** runs alongside, foundation pledges announced from the stage as a frank and friendly moment of peer pressure, and the **Dolphin Fund** launches into the open. The realness the crew is chasing, the thing they will know by feel, is money given away without it feeling like a loss, and forty-two venues all lighting up for the same impossible birthday.



Chapter Four – The Machinery Beneath the Floorboards

The calendar is the part you see. Beneath it run five interlocking systems, and very nearly every milestone in this story turns out, on inspection, to be one of them wearing a costume.

The Trust Graph. A knowledge graph (what you know and have made) overlaid with a promise graph (what you have staked and delivered). Every hitchhiker carries their own, a private constellation that hardens, as trust accrues, into “a city with structures and squares”: the City of Mages. Dave’s pipeline runs in three honest steps, *intent then promise then trust*, and never skips the middle one.

The Pan-Galactic Time Bank. A mutual-credit time bank with a layer nobody else has bothered to build: pledge forty-two hours, earn forty-two credits, the whole ledger summing neatly to zero, with a portion donated or invested into guides that hold group accounts. **Threshold smart contracts** automatically refund if a guide’s target is not met, which quietly solves the cold-start problem that kills most of these things. And the hours are an honesty box: a top lawyer and an eight-year-old bill at exactly the same rate, which the Guide finds entirely admirable and most economists find upsetting.

The Game of 42. The growth engine and the geometry at once. You start solo, find your complements, reach six (a minimal project), and then you *bud*: seven groups of six make forty-two, and to grow beyond that you bud *another* forty-two rather than bloat the first. The roles of **Head, Heart, and Hands**, with their mirror images, fold a hexagon into a flower into the seats of the *Heart of Gold*. Diversity here is not decoration. It is load-bearing: an assembly that lacks it does not fly.

The three bonding curves. Each guide becomes real by crossing a threshold on one of three curves: money, hours, or trust. Together the three *are* the guide’s identity, and they carry a rather neat security property thrown in for free: a guide that is private on one axis must be public on another, so it can never be attacked on both at once.

Guides, agents, media, and money. The guides (gu.id.earth) are the core vibe-coding unit. The agents (Marvin, Eddie, Deep Thought) keep the local-versus-cloud tension honest. **Hitchhiker Radio and TV** carry the culture along the airwaves. The **MyTerms** layer gives every relationship its own two-party data agreement. And the money runs on a crypto-economic white paper, on **patron.fish** (forty-two times 42k, which lands near 1.67M), on a fair token launch, and on the **Dolphin Fund**. The brand stays deliberately multi-perspectival, launches gently, defends itself by way of Bushido, and promises only what is already, demonstrably, built.



Chapter Five – The Horizon (2028, and the Things on the 42)

Past the Annual Galactic Meeting, the crew stops planning what it can build and starts back-casting from what it can barely imagine. This is the least-developed and most aspirational part of the whole tale, and also, not coincidentally, the entire reason any of it exists. A second AGM, around 4 July 2028, takes aim at 4.2M members and \$42M.

🔗 Living Sovereign Compute – 5 November 2027

A viable, self-sustaining, peer-to-peer network of sovereign data centres and home labs, stitched together with national capacity, carrying a credible chance of out-computing the great foundation models on their own ground. It is wanted by the **data-dignity** movement, by indigenous communities seeking culturally-owned models, by governments that are neither American nor Chinese, by universities and home labs and libraries. The honest conflict, stated without flinching: you cannot easily launch an *alternative* to the frontier labs, politely requesting some forty-two billion in compute, while courting those same labs as *partners*. The resolution is sequence and ceremony: provoke with sovereign compute first, then route the labs through the citizen assemblies and a trust ceremony before they are ever allowed near the commons.

🌍 The Poly-Singularity – 2028

And here, at last, the destination, which turns out to be two faces of one arrival. What the early sessions called **The Unsingularity** and **Deep Thought Realized** are, in this reading, the same event seen from two sides.

The governance face (The Unsingularity, around February 2028). A planetary structure of forty-two assemblies, by forty-two regions, by forty-two sub-regions, earns genuine respect as a way to govern Earth with human *and* non-human voices. People claim their own biome from the bottom up through an ide.earth globe; nature, the young, the indigenous, and the unrecognised nations all get a seat. It is deliberation, not a survey: a selected, trust-graphed assembly meeting across a full year, producing sincere answers you can actually sit and listen to, translated, naturally, by the babble fish. Sentiment shifts from bleak centralisation toward something that looks a great deal like hope, and the people who used to talk up *the singularity* begin, ever so slowly, to find it a little embarrassing.

The answers face (Deep Thought Realized, around June 2028). Staged as a global, Live-Aid-style moment, the frontier labs bequeath billions of tokens and a pool of compute to a neutral third space, so credentialed Hitchhikers can work the great questions, and the urgent present-day ones, out in the open. A non-monetary path to relevance opens: pledge forty-two hours, earn the credits, so that reputation and

learning lead and the people priced out of the frontier find another way in. The proof, fittingly, is emotional. People should probably cry.

What they become together. Every person and every community holds their own local boundary and their own large language model, and the plurality of those sovereign computes federates into one mutual capable of answering the planet’s largest questions without anyone surrendering their ground. It is, very deliberately, not a data lake. The worth comes from privacy kept, not data pooled. This is the poly-singularity: the largest mutual the Hitchhikers can imagine, grown patiently from the smallest of local sovereignties. Many singularities, and no centre at all.

↪ On the 42 – the things held off the calendar

And held off the calendar, where the deepest intent waits without fuss, sits the stretch set: **RWA Embassies and a Hitchhiker HOA** (social housing, co-living, a Land Lab, a research network); a **Global Double Erasmus** knowledge-exchange that “feeds the brain” of Deep Thought; **post-quantum cryptography** as “**Hitchhiker Agility**,” moving fluidly between cryptographic systems being, after all, precisely what a Hitchhiker does; the long-cherished **Apple local-AI partnership** north star; the **Marvin Tesla Robot** (a 42k robotics fellowship); and the **Game Olympics**, cheerfully news-jacking the Summer 2028 Olympics. None of it scheduled. All of it meant.



Chapter Six – The Perils Still on the Board

No honest adventure pretends the map is finished. The crew's discipline is to raise the hard questions early and pin them where everyone can see them, rather than tuck them behind the scenery. These are precisely the threads where a Vision Fish's judgement is worth the most.

There is the **5 November collision** (Devcon Mumbai and a forty-two-location festival on the same night, two places at once, to be staffed with great care). There is the **IP transfer timing** in 2027 (what becomes of the tokens and of Marvin before the IP enters the new company). There is the **frontier-labs relationship**, where partnership is resolved through Deep Thought and the assembly trust-ceremony but the *acquisition* terms remain open. There is the question of **governance when it succeeds**: who allocates the donated compute, and whether that process is locked down before the Poly-Singularity rather than after. There is the **environmental critique** of compute, its water and its energy, named by the crew as the chief danger and as yet unanswered. There is **lottery legality** across jurisdictions (doable in the UK, a stretch globally). There is the standing vigilance against **bad money and equity grabs**. There is the unresolved **AI-provider strategy**, frontier partner against pure local-first, deferred to brand. And there is the **trust-graph visualisation** itself, which has to be meaningful and not merely a scatter of dots, and which is left open on purpose, as an invitation.

That invitation, as it happens, has your name on it.



Chapter Seven – The Part With Your Name On It

Here is the message that arrived for you, several thousand words ago.

A Vision Fish is not a spectator, and was never meant to be. The early milestones are exactly where your judgement and your network matter most: an introduction made at the right moment, a stage offered, a willingness to lend your name to a founding-donor wall when lending it still costs something. And the later milestones are where that early trust compounds, with interest, into governance and compute at planetary scale. The wager is the one from the very first page: that a federation of kept boundaries, each one holding its own model and its own voice, can become a single global mutual in which privacy is realised as value. And that this is a markedly better future than the one enormous lake everyone else is so quietly, so industriously, busy building.

The crew measures its own success strangely, and you should know how, because it is how they will measure this. Not by reach but by **serendipity**, the doors that open before you knock. By **people pitching it back to you**, a room of strangers all vibing it out and giggling because they are building the same thing in their own words. By **emotion**, the Live-Aid test, the family-dinner test, the simple fact that people should be moved enough to cry and unembarrassed enough to mention it. By **the map filling in**, the globe freckled over with pins. By **money that does not feel extractive**. And by **something you can actually point to**: the visualisation, shimmering live, from real data, right there in front of you.

If that is a future you would like to be part of, then this saga is the shape of the next two years, the dates all intentions and the numbers all motifs, and there is a seat in it, one of forty-two, waiting.

You have read to the end, which the crew takes as a promising sign. You have not panicked, which is the other one.



Assembled, with some affection, from nineteen transcribed planning sessions and the federated milestone wikis where each session lives in full. Every event and every system in the briefing is here, wearing story clothes. Dates are intentions. Numbers are motifs. Prepared for the Vision Fish.

Don't Panic.